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Could California ban Skittles? Bill targeting 'dangerous and toxic' additives moves forward

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A California bill that would ban additives found in foods like Skittles and fruit cups took a step forward this week, toward banning certain processed snacks — or at least changing their recipes.

Assembly Bill 418, introduced in February by Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Woodland Hills, and Assemblywoman Buffy Wicks, D-Oakland, passed the health committee with bipartisan support Tuesday. It would "ban the sale of processed foods containing certain dangerous and toxic chemicals."

Here's what to know about which additives the bill targets, including red dye No. 3, what's next for the bill and what happens if it becomes law:

What happens if the bill becomes law?

The bill isn't intended to ban any products, according to a March Statement from Gabriel's office, but that's what could happen if it is signed into law and companies don't make the switch.

What's next for the bill?

The health committee passed the bill with bipartisan support (12 to 1) and it is now re-referred to the Committee on Environmental Safety and Toxic Materials.

If it makes it out of committees, it will head to the assembly floor where it will need a majority vote to move forward.

A bill does not become law until it is passed by both the Assembly and Senate — as long as the governor doesn't veto it.

What substances would the bill ban?

AB 418 would ban the following ingredients:

Brominated vegetable oil - Keeps citrus flavors from rising to the top of beveragesPotassium bromate - Strengthens the flour of packaged baked goodsPropylparaben - Preservative that kills mold and other microorganismsRed dye No. 3 - Gives food a bright-red cherry colorTitanium dioxide - Prevents food from breaking down

Each of these chemicals is banned in the European Union, according to a news release from Gabriel's office.

If passed, when would it take effect?

The bill states the additives would be illegal by 2025.

What is red dye No. 3?

The long-time controversial chemical red dye No. 3 is a synthetic dye derived from petroleum, according to the nonprofit consumer organization Consumer Reports.

There's evidence that the dye as well as the other ingredients is detrimental to the health of animals, but not

humans. High doses of red dye no. 3 have been found to cause cancer in animals.

What foods could be banned?

The ingredients center stage of AB 418 are commonly found in processed foods including cereals, candy, soda, packaged baked goods and frozen dinners.

Meaning, odds are you've consumed the additives before.

Here are some examples:

Skittles contain titanium dioxideRing Pops and Hot Tamales have red dye No. 3

The ingredients are present in thousands of other food products, from fruit cups to baked goods, according to an Environmental Working Group database.

The Bee's Lindsey Holden contributed to this story

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